Chapter Four

The Lost Homeland

Between 1127 and 1150, the Song are exiled by the Jin,
the Dai Viet adopt the Mandate of Heaven,
and a Khmer king builds the biggest temple on earth

IN 1127, the poet Li Qingzhao and her husband abandoned their home and fled from the advancing troops of the Jurchen. They traveled south with a cartful of rare manuscripts and antique bronzes, leaving behind them a lifetime's collection of books and art. Before they reached the southern city of Nanjing, where they would settle as refugees, the Jurchen burned their home to the ground. The Song dynasty, which had been ruling from the Yellow river valley since 960, was driven from its capital city of Kaifeng; the Song emperor Qinzong was hauled north and imprisoned until his death; the dominance of the Song over China was broken.[1]

"The long night passes slowly," Li Qingzhao wrote, wistfully, of her vanished home, "with few happy thoughts / Then I dream of the capital and see the road back to it. . . ." But she never followed the road; Kaifeng was lost forever.[2]

For the Song dynasty, the defeat was both unexpected and embarrassing.